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Psychoanalytic ego psychology: A European perspective¹

MARCO CONCI 

Abstract

The best way to reconstruct the history of psychoanalytic ideas is to begin from the study not of theories, but of the various authors and their contexts. Important contributions to the study of the ego in Europe had already come from Ferenczi and Fenichel, well before Hartmann founded Ego Psychology (EP), which became mainstream in North America. In Europe, before World War II, significant contributions to what here is called “psychoanalytic ego psychology” (Pep) (contrasted with Hartmann’s EP) came from Anna Freud, Paul Federn, and Gustav Bally. After World War II, contributions came from Alexander Mitscherlich, Paul Parin, and Johannes Cremerius in the German-speaking community, and from Joseph Sandler in the UK. If this is the case, we should then talk of “ego psychologies” in the same way as we talk of the various object relations theories. Pep – as it was described in the guiding principles formulated by Fenichel in the 1930s – keeps informing the clinical work of many psychoanalysts, even if they are not fully aware of it. For example, it represents the basic ingredient of the empirically verifiable “psychoanalytic therapy” formulated in detail by Helmut Thomä and Horst Kächele.

Keywords: *psychoanalytic ego psychology, Heinz Hartmann, history of psychoanalysis, Otto Fenichel, Thomä and Kächele.*

Introduction

The best way to approach such a complex topic as psychoanalytic ego psychology (Pep) is to follow the historical approach that Sigmund Freud himself recommended in his 1923 contribution with the title “Two encyclopedia articles” as the best way to understand psychoanalysis (Freud, 1923a). This is exactly the type of definition that Otto Fenichel (1897–1946) gave of psychoanalytic ego psychology in 1935, that is:

The history of psychoanalysis brought it about that we became acquainted with the unconscious before the conscious and with the repressed before the ego. Nowadays the psychology of the ego stands in the center of our investigations. (Fenichel, 1935; 1953, p. 348)

Such a general and wide definition is what stimulated me to distinguish Pep from Heinz Hartmann’s (1894–1970) particular version of it, which I will

call Ego Psychology (EP). In other words, I look at Pep as a necessary phase of the whole work carried out by Freud in his attempt to define the ways of working of the unconscious, with particular regard to the unconscious aspects of clinical phenomena such as resistance and anxiety. These could not be accounted for well enough on the basis of his original model of the mind, the topographical model – originally formulated by Freud (1900) in “The interpretation of dreams”. Such a definition of Pep, as a specific phase in the development of psychoanalysis, actually represents a rather recurrent theme in Otto Fenichel’s second series of *Collected papers*. Here is what he wrote in this regard in 1939:

In ‘Ego psychology’, as it is called, psychoanalysis investigates matters which have long been studied by other psychologies as well. But it does this in a different way from them, prepared as it is by its previous exploration of the instincts (or drives). It approaches the subject from a *genetic* standpoint, in that it represents

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¹This is a not only largely extended, but also newly conceived version of the preliminary contribution written by the author for the item “Ego psychology” (<https://online.flippingbook.com/view/544664/110>) of the Inter-Regional Encyclopedic Dictionary of Psychoanalysis (IRED), the dictionary originally conceived by Stefano Bolognini and published by the International Psychoanalytic Association. “Ego psychology,” coauthored by Harold Blum, Marco Conci, Olga Santa Maria, and Eva Papiasvili, has been online since December 2020. This work of revision was made between summer 2021 and summer 2022, its first result being Conci (2021). Translations of texts with no English original have been made by the author. The author thanks Paolo Migone for his many instances of useful feedback, and the journal’s editorial board colleagues, particularly Grigoris Maniadakis and Carlo Bonomi, for their intellectual support and appreciation.

ego phenomena as originating from the interplay of instincts and environmental influences. Thus, one no longer exposes oneself to the suspicion of being an adherent of ‘individual psychology’ if one wishes to investigate problems concerning *the will to power* which – in our society even more than in others – is a powerful motive of human action. It is only a matter of *how* one conducts the investigation. (Fenichel, 1939; 1954, p. 141; emphasis in the original).

Defining Pep as a necessary phase in the development of psychoanalysis not only confirms the nature of the analytic discourse as a “research work in progress,” but also allows us to better account for the variety of ways in which this new phase was dealt with by a large variety of authors, in Europe and in North America. In other words, although only the approach to Pep developed by Heinz Hartmann and his group ended being viewed and propagated as “EP,” not only did many other authors contribute to this field of study and research, but all of them did so according to their own priorities, interests, and personalities. This is what I will deal with in this article.

In fact, this is true also for Hartmann and his group, whose original inspiration came from a book which Hartmann published in 1927 with the title *Die Grundlagen der Psychoanalyse* (The foundations of psychoanalysis); this was never translated into English, but it was translated into Italian, in 1981. In this work, Hartmann presented psychoanalysis as a natural science, and showed how important it was to redefine it in such a way as to make of psychoanalysis a discipline capable of collaborating with general psychology – and with the social sciences. Hartmann’s 1939 monograph *Ego psychology and the problem of adaptation* (English edition, Hartmann, 1958) can be seen as his way of satisfying this priority of his – which he later further articulated with his closest collaborators Ernst Kris (1900–1957) and Rudolph Loewenstein (1898–1976) (see Hartmann, 1964; Hartmann, Kris, & Loewenstein, 1964). Such a priority and such a perspective became not only a school, but even the dominant psychoanalytic paradigm, between 1950 and 1970, but only in the USA.

This was never the case in Europe, where the hegemonic agenda and the monolithic character of what was also called “American Ego Psychology” ended up limiting the reception of Pep as a whole. The way in which Pep was reimported from the USA to Europe almost exclusively in the unilateral form given to it by Heinz Hartmann and his collaborators was documented by Paul Parin (1916–2009) in his 1990 article “Die Beschädigung der Psychoanalyse in der angelsächsischen Emigration und ihre Rückkehr nach Europa” (The damage to psychoanalysis

in its Anglo-Saxon emigration and its return to Europe). In his formulation of the item “Moi (Ego-Psychology)” for the *Dictionnaire international de la psychanalyse* edited by Alain de Mijolla, Ernst Federn (1914–2007) gave the following succinct formulation to Paul Parin’s line of thought:

Hartmann’s concept is partly a consequence of the transplantation of psychoanalysis in the Anglo-Saxon world. The exact translation of *Ich* into English would be *Self*, and the Latin word *Ego* transforms the *Ichpsychologie*, which becomes in English *Ego Psychology*, into something strange and foreign. And then the *Self* was translated into German with the *Selbst*. (Federn, 2002, p. 1026)

Dealing with the item “Ego Psychology” in the very good Italian dictionary published by Einaudi (Turin) in 2007, Mauro Fornaro and Paolo Migone not only totally identified Pep with EP, but even came to the point of not mentioning any post-war European development in this field – as, for example, represented by the work of Paul Parin himself (Fornaro & Migone, 2007). The same is true for the German dictionary edited in 2008 by Wolfgang Mertens and Bruno Waldvogel, in which the author of the item “Ich-Psychologie” (Hartkamp, 2008), after carrying out the same operation as Fornaro and Migone, limited himself to mentioning only the two minor German authors Peter Fürstenau and Annelise Heigl-Evers, as opposed to the important contributions given to both Pep and EP by the two important German authors Alexander Mitscherlich (1908–1982) and Hermann Argelander (1920–2004) (see below). If, on the one hand, it is true that the major texts of (North American) EP were translated and published in Italy and Germany, it is on the other hand also true that Pep survived in Europe not only in the form given to it by Heinz Hartmann and his collaborators, but also in the form of a series of autonomous contributions (see below), not to mention – as we will also see below – Pep being still widely used today, in everyday clinical practice, with particular regard to Germany.

In this context there also took place what we can call the lack of reception of EP in France and the Francophone analytic world, as we can gather from the book *La psychanalyse américaine* published in 2005 by the serious French-Canadian scholar Hélène Tessier. Judging EP not in terms of its agenda (to develop psychoanalysis as a natural science), but in terms of its results (in the first place, pre-conflictual ego functioning and the conflict-free sphere), the author can easily demonstrate how “cette vision s’éloigne considérablement de la perspective de Freud” (such a perspective is considerably distant from the perspective of Freud)

(Tessier, 2005, p. 39). Elisabeth Roudinesco and Michel Plon formulated a similar opinion in their *Dictionnaire de la psychanalyse*: as much as EP privileges the Ego, neglects the id, the unconscious, and what in French psychoanalysis is called “*le sujet*,” it turns psychoanalysis into “a religion of happiness and health” (see Roudinesco & Plon, 1997, p. 243).

Last but not least, the important book edited by Martin Bergmann (1913–2014) in 2000 with the title *The Hartmann era* centers around the full identification of (North American) Pep with the work of Heinz Hartmann and his collaborators; second, we find in it the absolute lack of any significant contribution to EP coming from Europe. In Bergmann’s words:

The fact is that the Hartmann school remained confined to the United States. With the exception of Anna Freud and Willi Hoffer, who may be regarded as honorary members of this group, no thinker in Europe or South America drew inspiration from Hartmann. (Bergmann, 2000a, p. 7)

Such a superficial point of view can be ascribed to the deficits of international dialogue and exchange which André Green (1927–2012) and Otto Kernberg dealt with in two of their interventions to the same volume (Green, 2000; Kernberg, 2000). Here is what André Green says:

You can say everything in defense of Hartmann, but you cannot say that he has been fostering dialogue. Again, I come back to international conferences and their failure. How is it that such an important endeavor can take place ... with no change at all in the literature? After a congress each one went back home and continued to practice, to lecture and to write, as if nothing happened! (Green, 2000, p. 136)

And here is how Otto Kernberg immediately reacted to Green:

I think the last point is so important that we should have it on the table very clearly. The German *totschweigen* means to silence to death. It is a way in which you deal with thoughts that are not permitted to exist, and it was the technique of the Communist party in the Soviet Union. Even in photographs they eliminated those who no longer existed. We must confess that there has been such an unfortunate tendency in our literature, and Hartmann certainly participated actively and leadingly in eliminating from his statements anything going on simultaneously in the international psychoanalytic debate about all issues. That, I think, is tragic, and he did it with the Kleinians, and the Kleinians did it with the Anna Freudians. It was more a general problem, but he certainly did not go beyond it. (Kernberg, 2000, p. 137)

Accurately studying the history of Pep can allow us to define, for every single author who dealt with it –

with particular regard to Europe, before and after World War II – a specific scientific agenda, and thus overcome the monolithic character of its North American configuration. The negative consequences of this for the analytic discourse in the USA were clearly articulated also by the former ego-psychologist (and IPA president) Robert Wallerstein (1921–2014) in his 2002 article “The growth and transformation of American ego psychology.” Indeed, in some cases it will even be possible to connect such an agenda to a series of personal and biographical reasons.

A good way to further document the possibility of reconstructing the various approaches to Pep in terms of the scientific agendas of the psychoanalysts with whose contributions we will deal in this article is to again go back to Otto Fenichel. I am here referring to the way in which he, in his 1941 paper “Psychoanalysis of character,” talking about the “three reasons why psychoanalysis could not fail to be extended to ego psychology” (Fenichel, 1941a; 1954, p. 200), presented the first one as having been the clinical phenomenon of the patients’ resistance. This allowed him to very clearly state: “Thus it was the necessity for analyzing the resistance which in practice started psychoanalytic ego psychology” (p. 201). This is why we can say that the point of view of clinical psychoanalysis and of psychoanalytic technique was the specific perspective from which Otto Fenichel dealt with and contributed to Pep.

Before going on with the other authors, here is a further relevant fact worth mentioning: in the introductory chapter to the abovementioned book on *The Hartmann era* (Bergmann, 2000b), Martin Bergmann only marginally mentioned the fact that Otto Fenichel was an important pioneer of Pep before Heinz Hartmann’s branch of it dominated the field, and that the former was critical of the way in which the latter reformulated Freud’s (1923b) original articulation of Pep (see Bergmann, 2000a, p. 4). In fact, in his 1940 review of Heinz Hartmann’s (1939) “Ich-Psychologie und das Anpassungsproblem,” Otto Fenichel talked of the former’s concept of “‘sphere without conflict’ as perhaps somewhat misleading, as tending toward a *static* point of view” (Fenichel 1940b, p. 445; emphasis in the original).

And what are the agendas or specific perspectives which we can ascribe to the other authors with whom we will deal in this article? As far as Anna Freud (1895–1982) is concerned, we can look at developmental psychology as (together with conceptual and diagnostic research) having been her specific focus. As far as Paul Federn (1871–1950) is concerned, Pep meant for him a better understanding how to formulate and treat the clinical problems of patients with a damaged ego, a field in which he

was also a pioneer, as Anna Freud was in hers. Given his particular closeness to both Freud and Federn, we can see in Edoardo Weiss (1889–1970) the pioneer of what we can call a “comparative psychoanalytic ego psychology” – as we can also gather from the title of his 1957 article “A comparative study of psycho-analytical ego concepts”. Last but not least, among the European authors of the pre-war period we cannot overlook the role of Sándor Ferenczi (1873–1933), to whom Otto Fenichel himself attributed the merit of having laid “the foundation stone of the study of the ego ... in his paper ‘Stages in the development of the sense of reality’” (Fenichel, 1937; 1954, p. 47).

In, on the one hand, a historically well founded, and, on the other hand, a selective reconstruction of the major authors involved in the development of Pep, that is, the 1958 article “A historical review of psychoanalytic ego psychology” (Rapaport, 1958), David Rapaport (1911–1960) overlooked the contribution of both Sándor Ferenczi and Paul Federn, but formulated a scheme in four phases that can still be very useful for our purposes. He saw the first phase as terminating in 1897, in connection with Freud’s renunciation of the seduction theory; the second phase as terminating in 1923, with the publication of Freud’s “The ego and the id” (Freud, 1923b); the third phase as associated with Freud’s development of his own Pep, and lasting till 1937; and the fourth phase as coinciding with books from not only Anna Freud (1936) and Heinz Hartmann (1939), but also Karen Horney (1937) and H.S. Sullivan (1940), and as being characterized by the specific version of Pep formulated by Hartmann around his own concepts of innate (pre-conflictual) ego functioning and of ego autonomy. At the same time, Rapaport also assigned to the abovementioned third phase the work of post-Freudian authors such as Hermann Nunberg (1894–1970) and Robert Waelder (1900–1967), with particular regard to their contributions on the synthetic functions of the ego and the principle of multiple function. Of course, not only Rapaport’s conceptual research, but also his diagnostically oriented clinical work is an important part of North American EP – the latter finding widespread use in Europe, with particular regard to the handbook on psychological testing which he published together with Merton Gill (1914–1994) and Roy Schafer (1922–2018) (see Rapaport, Gill and Schafer, 1974). Last but not least, it is also interesting to see how the ego-psychological character of some of H.S. Sullivan’s work did not escape Rapaport’s attention.

And what about the specific European contributions to Pep? North American EP was an important source of inspiration for the unique and

multifaceted work that Alexander Mitscherlich performed in West Germany until his death in 1982 aged 73, in order not only to help his people elaborate the incredible disaster brought about by the twelve years of the Nazi regime (1932–1945), but also in order to bring an enlightened and socially critical psychoanalysis back to his country. From this point of view, the common denominator of his work was Freud’s 1928 plea to bring about such a stronger ego as to be able to listen to and follow *die Stimme der Vernunft* (the voice of reason; Freud, 1928). The same is true for Paul Parin in terms of both the ethnographic research work which he undertook in West Africa together with his wife Goldy Parin-Matthéy (1911–1997) and with Fritz Morgenthaler (1919–1984), and of the ego-psychologically based social critique which he systematically developed in Zurich. Furthermore, in his 1977 article “Das Ich und die Anpassungs-Mechanismen” (The ego and the mechanism of adaptation) he gave a specific new contribution to the point of view developed by Heinz Hartmann and his collaborators in terms of the concept of “role identification.” The same is true for the concept of the “scenic function of the ego,” formulated by Hermann Argelander, a collaborator of Alexander Mitscherlich.

Although (North American) EP was critically received by the colleagues of the Italian Psychoanalytic Society, and although its reception in terms of the translation of its literature took place outside of it (see below), we can look at Stefano Bolognini’s clinical priorities in terms of the systematic attention he has been giving to the ego-psychologically founded interaction between the ego and the self (see Bolognini, 2011). Stefano Bolognini is a former president of both the Italian Psychoanalytic Society and the International Psychoanalytic Association (IPA).

But, of course, the major contribution to Pep coming from Europe after World War II is represented by Joseph Sandler’s (1927–1998) integrative agenda, which allowed him – as Otto Kernberg did in North America – to bring Pep closer to object relations theories – and to the Kleinian tradition, with particular regard to the concept of “projective identification.”

Last but not least, very interesting and inspiring for the definition of the best approach to our topic is the position evolved by Leo Rangell (1913–2011), a former president of both the American Psychoanalytic Association and the IPA. As he explained in detail in his 2004 book *My life in theory*, after having been for many decades a protagonist of EP (see, for example, Rangell, 1965), he ended up developing the theoretical frame of what he called a “developed Freudian,” that is, a frame both centered on EP and also going beyond it, in terms of both interpersonal

and objects relations, and self-object dynamics. In other words, from this point of view we can speak of Pep not only as a school, and as a phase in the development of psychoanalysis, but also as a stable and still relevant perspective from which to look at the work we do in our field – what Leo Rangell would call a stable component of his “composite theory.”

Pep in Europe before World War II

Carlo Bonomi’s 2010 revisitation of the topic “Ferenczi and ego psychology” centers around a good demonstration of the crucial role played by the personal inclinations and interests of every single analyst in shaping their unique approach to the concept of the ego, and his formulation of his own Pep. Only one year after his first meeting with Freud, Ferenczi coined the term “introjection” (Ferenczi, 1909), which was thought of “as extension of the ego” (Ferenczi, 1912, p. 317). In 1913, following Freud’s pioneering paper on the “Two principles of mental functioning” (Freud, 1911), Ferenczi published the two important contributions to the psychoanalytic study of the ego: “Stages in the development of the sense of reality” (1913a) and “Belief, disbelief, and conviction” (1913b). The first deals with the transition from the pleasure principle to the reality principle, and the second reflects further on the impediments to independent judgment, a necessary instrument for engaging reality. In this paper, Ferenczi defined the sense of reality as not attainable by relying on authority, and this anticipates and explains an important aspect of his later opposition to Pep based on the structural model. In fact, according to it, and at variance with Ferenczi’s point of view, the patient’s sense of reality is considered to be enhanced by the introjection of the analyst as an auxiliary superego.

According to Bonomi, it was at the level of the technical problems encountered by the analyst at work with their patients that the mutual aversion and estrangement which gradually developed between Ferenczi’s line of thought and the ego-psychological concepts connected with the structural model emerged most clearly. But behind such technical differences there was also a different psychopathological perspective concerning the basic problems under which our patients suffer. According to Ferenczi, our patients suffer from a dissociation or lack of integration between the emotional and the cognitive dimensions of their mental life. According to, for example, Anna Freud, they suffer from the ego’s primary antagonism or innate hostility towards the instincts (see A. Freud, 1936; English 1946), that is, what David Rapaport called the

insufficient “control of structure over drive” (see Rapaport, 1957). This is what explains, on the one hand, the development of the so-called standard technique centered around the analyst’s abstinence from any form of participation in the relationship with the patient, and, on the other hand, Ferenczi’s gradual elaboration of an attitude of thoughtful participation in it. According to Bonomi, the crucial discovery behind these contrasting technical stances was “the discovery that the analyst induced repetition” (Bonomi, 2010, p. 109), with Pep reacting to it in terms of aiming at reducing or eliminating such a problem, and Ferenczi taking it seriously.

Another paradox connected to the way in which Ferenczi’s early interest in the ego ended up distancing him from the abovementioned direction taken by Pep consists in the fact that Hanns Sachs (1925) considered Ferenczi’s “active technique” as being founded upon Freud’s structural model, as if the analyst could determine a structural change by representing the ego-ideal (superego). If this was the direction in which James Strachey moved, allowing him to redefine the aim of therapy in terms of an “integral change in the nature of the patient’s superego” (Strachey, 1934, p. 279), and thus making the superego the fulcrum of psychotherapy, such a “metapsychological solution” of the problem of the relationship between analyst and patient did not at all satisfy Ferenczi. From his point of view, such a solution, by pretending an unattainable objectivity, produced the repression of the doubts and objections which naturally also accompany a therapeutic relationship, and this is why he ended up giving up Freud’s structural model, and ended up looking at the relationship between analyst and patient as “the fulcrum of psychotherapy” (see Bonomi, 2010, p. 121).

Already by 1927, Ferenczi had stopped clinging to a preconceived model of therapy, embracing instead the idea of a basic “elasticity” of technique (see Ferenczi, 1928). Later, in his *Clinical diary* (see Ferenczi, 1988), he would even wonder if one should not abandon “technique” altogether. Having systematically worked with a whole series of traumatized and dissociated patients, Ferenczi had come to view the main problem of the ego as being not its autonomy from instinctual pressures, as framed within Pep, but the preservation of its boundaries and of the feeling of oneself, that is, the *Ich-Gefühl*, as defined by Paul Federn (see Bonomi, 2010, p. 126). In Carlo Bonomi’s words:

This new sensibility with respect to the ego – which first appears in the paper ‘The unwelcome child’ (1929) – further modified Ferenczi’s understanding of the role of the analyst in precipitating repetition. He suddenly felt a great responsibility, and he began to stress that

the task of the analyst was to attenuate repetition. Once again, he tried to manage the problem *technically* – that is, by intentionally creating a benevolent and non-frustrating atmosphere. Yet he soon reached the conclusion that the quality of the relationship was not defined by its exterior aspects, but rather involved a more subtle participation that cannot be fully planned and controlled in advance. This final conclusion put an end to Ferenczi's hope to find the correct technique and to the notion that there is an ultimate solution to these problems that could be formulated in advance. (Bonomi, 2010, p. 127)

In the Introduction, we have already seen how Otto Fenichel welcomed Pep as a perspective through which it would have eventually been possible not only to better account for the clinical phenomenon of unconscious resistance, but also to more exactly formulate the basic principles of the analytic technique. Such a point of view was also shared by his Viennese colleagues Hermann Nunberg and Richard Sterba (1898–1989), and by the pioneer of the study and formulation of analytic technique Franz Alexander (1891–1964).

“Few papers have been as frequently quoted and have exerted an influence comparable to ‘The synthetic function of the Ego,’” wrote Martin Bergmann and Frank Hartmann in their introduction to Nunberg's paper in their 1976 handbook *The evolution of psychoanalytic technique* (Bergmann & Hartmann, 1976, p. 304). Going beyond Freud, Nunberg postulated the need for causality as a fundamental human need, and described the synthetic function of the ego as not merely unifying the entire personality, but also simplifying and bringing economy into the ego's mode of operation (see Nunberg, 1931, p. 129). In the 1934 article “The fate of the ego in analytic therapy”, Richard Sterba was the first analyst to speak of what would later be called “the therapeutic alliance,” and Bergmann and Hartmann consider his pioneering article as “the first contribution of this ego psychology to technique” (Bergmann & Hartmann, 1976, p. 361).

Very instructive in terms of the reception of Freud's structural model and in terms of the elaboration of its technical consequences are the two papers by Franz Alexander which Bergmann and Hartmann included in their abovementioned handbook, that is, the 1925 paper “A metapsychological description of the process of cure,” and the 1935 paper “The problem of psychoanalytic technique.” In the former paper, “one of the earliest responses of psychoanalytic technique to the structural theory” (Bergmann & Hartmann, 1976, p. 99), Alexander was the first analyst to advance the idea that “psychoanalytic technique should center its energy on the amelioration of the superego” (Bergmann &

Hartmann, 1976, p. 99). In the second paper, we find a very different point of view, strongly influenced by Nunberg's concept of the synthetic function of the ego:

In analytic therapy our main allies are the *striving of unconscious forces for expression and the integrating tendency of the conscious ego*. ... Nunberg's thesis that the psychoanalytic treatment is not only an analytic but simultaneously a synthetic process as well is fully valid. ... Through our interpretations, without fully realizing it, we actually do help the synthesis in the ego. (Alexander, 1935, pp. 610–611; emphasis in the original)

More theoretically than technically oriented is another classical paper, the 1930 paper by Robert Waelder “The principle of multiple function: observations on multi-determination” (Waelder, 2007). In it, the author looks at Freud's new model of the mind in terms of a whole mind, “whose interests” – wrote Lawrence Friedman in 2007 – “are diagrammed as separate structures in the theory, but are simultaneously served in some proportion by every act of the whole mind” (Friedman, 2007, p. 129). From this point of view, “id and ego are simply different aspects of the same psychic event” (p. 126). According to the principle of multiple function, “no attempted solution of a problem is possible which is not of such a type that it does not, at the same time, in some way or other, represent an attempted solution of other problems” (Waelder, 2007, p. 78). In his 1939 monograph *Ego psychology and the problem of adaptation*, Heinz Hartmann repeatedly mentioned Waelder's contribution to EP, and the affinity of their points of view can be easily guessed by the following words with which Lawrence Friedman revisited Hartmann's monograph in 1989:

Hartmann's monograph is an argument for the problem-solving value of all aspects of the mind and for the subordination of intelligence to the organism's larger, primarily social purposes. (Friedman, 1989, p. 526)

That “ego psychology antedated the Hartmann era by a number of decades” and that “the leading ego psychologist was Otto Fenichel” (Bergmann, 2000a, pp. 4 and 67) is substantiated by a large number of ego-psychological papers by Fenichel, starting with his 1926 paper on “Identification.” In the second volume of his *Collected papers*, edited in 1953 by Hanna Fenichel and David Rapaport, besides the already mentioned 1937 paper “Early stages of ego development,” we find also “Ego strength and ego weakness” (1938a), “Ego disturbances and their treatment” (1938b), “The study of defense mechanisms and its importance for psychoanalytic technique” (1940), and “The ego and the

affects” (1941b). These are the clinically oriented papers which accompanied and followed his ego-psychological reformulation of analytic technique, as we can find in his paper “Concerning the theory of psychoanalytic technique” (originally published in German in 1935; Fenichel, 1935), and in the lectures on analytic technique which he held in Vienna in the fall of 1936. Translated into English by David Brunswick and published in the *Psychoanalytic Quarterly* in 1938–1939 under the title *Problems of psychoanalytic technique*, they came out in book form in 1941; only in 2001 did Michael Giefer and Elke Mühlleitner publish these important lectures in the original German.

“Concerning the theory of psychoanalytic technique” is the paper by Fenichel in which we find the sentence “Nowadays the psychology of the ego stands in the center of our investigations” (Fenichel, 1935; 1953, p. 348), mentioned at the beginning of the Introduction. And here is how Fenichel formulates his ego-psychological redefinition of analytic technique:

All those fine differences in the consciousness of man, which have been studied by the non-analytic schools ... now come within the sights of analysis, too. No doubt that psychoanalytic technique stands to gain much from this through the refinement of ‘resistance interpretation’ ... But let us not forget, either, that the preceding exploration of the unconscious makes it possible for the psychoanalyst to approach the phenomena of the ego, the differences of consciousness and the phenomena of self-regard, in a fundamentally different manner from other schools: psychoanalysis must explain these phenomena too as arising from an interplay between unconscious – and in the final analysis, biological – instinctual tendencies, and influences of the external world. (Fenichel, 1935; 1953, p. 348)

And here is how Martin Bergmann and Frank Hartmann introduced this important paper by Fenichel in their abovementioned handbook:

One can see from this paper how embattled the position of the early psychoanalytic ego psychologists was in the 1930s. On the one hand, Fenichel argues against Theodor Reik and Melanie Klein, who were all too ready to make interpretations about the id without regard to the readiness of the ego to absorb these interpretations. On the other hand, ego psychologists argue against Reich, and even more against Kaiser, who wished to limit all interpretations to resistance interpretations. ... It is a forceful exposition of the principles of analytic ego psychology in the field of technique. (Bergmann & Hartmann, 1976, p. 448)

These last words by Bergmann and Hartmann are even more appropriate for Fenichel’s seven chapters of *Problems of psychoanalytic technique*, in which we find a whole series of formulations that we can consider

as being still relevant today. Towards the end of the first introductory lecture, we can for example read:

Psychoanalytic technique is a complicated matter. Its tool is the unconscious of the analyst which intuitively comprehends the unconscious of the patient. Its aim is to lift this comprehension out of intuition into scientific activity. ... The subject matter, not the method, of psychoanalysis, is irrational. (Fenichel, 1941c, pp. 12–13)

A high point in the formalization of his method is what we find in the third lecture, “The first analytical steps – Dynamics and economics of interpretation,” in which Fenichel formulates the following “generally known rules,” which still characterize the ego-psychological approach to technique:

(a) ‘One should always start the interpretation at the surface’ ... (b) ‘The patient determines the subject matter of the analytic hour’ ... (c) ‘Interpretation of resistance precedes interpretation of content’ ... (d) ‘We should avoid too deep and too superficial interpretations’. (Fenichel, 1941c, pp. 44–45)

Even more interesting, from the point of view of our topic, is the following lecture, dedicated to the “Structural aspects of interpretation,” in which Fenichel shows how “the analyst works *exclusively* upon the *ego*” (Fenichel, 1941c, p. 54; emphasis in the original), and comes up with the following final formulation:

That the analyst should carry on his work of interpretation from a position equidistant from ego, id, and superego, is a rule suggested by Anna Freud (1936) which can be paraphrased as meaning that the analyst must see all three aspects of psychic phenomena and in the struggle between them remain neutral. Essentially however, he begins always to work with the ego and only through the ego can he reach the id and the superego; in this sense he is always closer to the ego than to the other two. (Fenichel, 1941c, p. 70)

Equally relevant for our contemporary daily clinical work is the ego-psychological approach of a phenomenological nature developed by Paul Federn in connection with his life-long passion for helping and therapeutically working with the sickest patients, those that Freud defined as not amenable to treatment, or *übertragungsunfähig*, that is, incapable of transference. On the basis of his very rich clinical experience, Federn conceptualized psychosis, with particular regard to schizophrenia, not in terms of psychic conflict, but in terms of a psychological deficiency connected with the patient’s family environment. Psychoanalytically speaking, a psychosis is for Federn a “sickness of the ego,” characterized by an “insufficient cathexis of the ego” and accompanied by a “pathological or insufficient ego feeling.” To such a phenomenological approach,

based on what the ego actually is, belong also the concepts of “ego borders” and “ego states,” aimed at describing and possibly measuring a patient’s subjective sense of unity in a way in which Freud’s and Hartmann’s genetic-functional approaches do not allow us to do – concerned as they are with the ego’s genesis and functions. According to Paul Federn, the ego also originated together with the id, but independently from it, and is already present at birth.

Only in 1952 did Edoardo Weiss put together his training analyst’s papers connecting his clinical work with psychotic patients with his study of their ego in the anthology *Ego psychology and the psychoses*, a very good document in Paul Federn’s legacy (Federn, 1972). Among them, we can mention the 1926 paper “Some variations in ego-feelings” and the 1931 paper “The analysis of psychotics,” both published in the *International Journal of Psychoanalysis*.

Historically and conceptually very interesting is the fact of how such a legacy was shaped by Federn’s great conflict between, on the one hand, his need to stay as close as possible to Freud (of whom he, together with Anna Freud, became the official representative in Vienna after 1923) and to his theoretical and clinical orientation and, on the other hand, his need to freely pursue his clinical interest with the sickest patients and to develop his own theoretical point of view, that is, his own branch of Pep. If Edoardo Weiss played a crucial role in helping Federn develop his own point of view, Federn’s son Ernest spent many years of his life writing about his father’s life and work, in a way which is still worth mentioning:

Federn had started out with trying to find a clinical proof for Freud’s theory of narcissism and in doing so he developed a theory of narcissism and the ego which differed from that of Freud. The papers on this subject are very hard to comprehend and suffer from a desperate effort on the part of Federn to use Freudian terms for observations Freud himself never made. ... During Freud’s life-time Federn was not aware that he had been contradicting Freud and according to a personal communication of Hermann Nunberg, neither did Freud. The latter, however, had not found Federn’s papers about ego feelings and narcissism particularly appealing and felt that they were complicating the problems rather than clarifying. Freud remained cool also to the treatment of psychoses with a modified psychoanalytic technique, in spite of having suggested it earlier. ... To the extent that Federn could treat psychotics successfully and found them appealing and treatable, he had differed from Freud. Ultimately the majority of psychoanalytic psychiatrists have sided with Federn as expressed in a number of books. (E. Federn, 1972, p.32)

One of the most important of these books was Ping-Nie Pao’s *Schizophrenic disorders: Theory and treatment from a psycho-dynamic point of view* (Pao, 1979). As a director of the Chestnut Lodge Hospital (Rockville, Maryland) and a heir of the tradition of psychotherapeutic work with the sickest patients inaugurated by H.S. Sullivan and Frieda Fromm-Reichmann (1889–1957), Pao was in the best position to summarize the various theoretical approaches to schizophrenia developed by psychoanalysis, giving a prominent place to Federn’s work and legacy. Pao dedicated to this topic the twenty pages of Chapter 10, “The place of Federn’s ‘ego psychology’ in a contemporary theory of schizophrenia,” based on an article by the same title published by him in 1975 in the *International Review of Psycho-Analysis*. In it he introduced the reader to Federn’s basic terminology (ego feeling, ego boundaries, ego states and ego cathexis), and to his conceptualization of schizophrenia, coming to the conclusion that “we may still be greatly benefited by reading Federn’s attempts at grappling for solutions half a century ago on problems which are still very much with us” (Pao, 1975, p. 479).

Three authors active before and after World War II

Not only Edoardo Weiss and Anna Freud, but also Gustav Bally (1893–1966) was active in the field of Pep both before and after World War II. Bally was a Swiss medical doctor who trained as an analyst at the Berlin Psychoanalytic Institute, and worked as an analyst in Berlin between 1926 and 1932 before going back to Zurich, where he died in 1966. He played a crucial role in the transmission of his ego-psychological training and orientation to a whole series of younger and important colleagues, who kept it alive into the 1970s–1990s in Switzerland, Germany and Italy. In fact, after introducing the German medical student Alexander Mitscherlich, who had escaped Switzerland during the war, to psychoanalysis, Bally became a very close friend of his – as we can read in Timo Hoyer’s 2008 biography of Mitscherlich. Furthermore, Bally was the training analyst of Gaetano Benedetti (1920–2013) and Fritz Meerwein (1922–1989) in the 1950s, and of Johannes Cremerius (1918–2002) in the early 1960s.

As far as Bally’s contribution to Pep and to EP is concerned, his 1933 article “Frühe Entwicklungsstadien des Ichs. Primäre Objektliebe” (Early phases of development of the ego. Primary object love) was mentioned twice by Heinz Hartmann in his monograph *Ego psychology and the problem of adaptation* (1958). Through the first one we can see Bally work in the same direction as Anna Freud:

Bally (1933) has convincingly shown that the prerequisite of learning by play is a state in which ‘nourishment and protection against enemies’ are assured; and his attempt to derive the phylogenesis of man’s mind from the evolution of the motor apparatus led him to believe that the protracted parental care is one of the causes of this evolution. The fact, stressed by Anna Freud, that for the small child the external world is a strong ally against his instinctual drives, is also related to the extensive parental care. (Hartmann, 1958, pp. 29–30)

In 1945, Bally was able to bring his research work on early development and on the role of play to fruition through the publication of the book *Vom Ursprung und von den Grenzen der Freiheit: Eine Deutung des Spiels bei Tier und Mensch* (On the origin and the limits of freedom: An interpretation of play in animals and human beings).

In the fall of 1908, the young Edoardo Weiss left his native Trieste to go to Vienna to study medicine, and he immediately contacted Freud, who sent him to his close collaborator Paul Federn, with whom he underwent his training analysis, becoming a member of the Vienna Society in 1913 – before graduating from medical school. At the end of World War I, he went back to his native Trieste, working in the local psychiatric hospital until the end of the 1920s. At this point, with Freud’s encouragement, he moved to Rome, where he was eventually able to train his first pupils (Nicola Perrotti and Emilio Servadio being the most important), bring to life the Italian Psychoanalytic Society that he had cofounded in 1925, and found the Italian *Rivista Italiana di Psicoanalisi*. In it, he published various ego-psychological papers, for example “Il Super-io” (The super-ego; 1933), and “La parte inconscia dell’Io” (The unconscious part of the ego; 1934). Because of the Racial Laws promulgated by Mussolini’s Regime in 1938, he left Italy for the USA, going first to Topeka and then to Chicago. He had a specific interest in agoraphobic patients, whom he treated from an ego-psychological point of view, and about whom he wrote before and after the war (see Weiss, 1935, 1953).

Having kept in close touch all his life with not only Paul Federn, but also Sigmund Freud (see Weiss, 1970), Weiss developed a unique capacity to see and value both their points of view, and this allowed him to write in 1957 what we can call the first comparative ego-psychological paper, “A comparative study of psycho-analytical ego concepts.” Taking into account not only such an openness, but also the fact that Weiss’s wife, the Slovenian pediatrician Vanda Shrenger, worked along Jungian lines (see Corsa, 2017), we can dare see in his tolerance and pluralism an important ingredient of the

ways in which psychoanalysis developed in Italy after World War II (see Conci, 2019; David, 1990). In addition, given the fact that Heinz Kohut was exposed to Edoardo Weiss’s teaching at the Chicago Institute, we can also look at his self-psychology as an extension of Paul Federn’s point of view, and this in as much it made of the self (as Federn had made of the ego) the main focus of our attention and treatment.

Anna Freud’s 1936 book *The ego and the mechanisms of defense* was the most important book on Pep after Freud’s “Inhibition, symptom and anxiety” (1926), and it antedated the original German version of Hartmann’s *Ego psychology and the problem of adaptation* by three years. Paul Gray (1982) stressed the resistances that Anna Freud’s book evoked among analysts, not excluding Freud, who referred to her work only once. In fact – as Gray demonstrated – Freud, the founder of Pep, was not himself an ego-psychologist. This is also why, in his exposition of Anna Freud’s contribution to EP, Martin Bergmann stresses the way in which Hartmann’s perspective represented the best theoretical framework for her own developmental research work (see Bergmann, 2000a, pp. 46–49). Anna Freud herself did not fail to admit this in her homage to Hartmann in the festschrift in his honor:

The child analyst’s thinking, governed as it is by the developmental aspects of the human personality, does not thrive on the basis of drive psychology alone, but needs to range freely in the whole theoretical field of psychoanalysis, according equal significance to id, ego, and superego, to depth and surface, as Hartmann does. This creates the specific links between his work and the child analyst’s thinking. ... So far as I am convinced, I have tried to take care of this by establishing the concept of *developmental lines*, contributed to both from the side of the id and of the ego development; these developmental lines lead from child’s state of immaturity to the gradual setting up of mature personality and are, in fact, the result of interaction between maturation, adaptation, and structuralization. (A. Freud, 1966, p.17 and p. 21; emphasis in the original)

In his 1985 biography of Anna Freud, the German psychologist Wilhlem Salber was able to show how her developmental viewpoint was closely connected to a life full of conflicts, turning points, changes, and developments (Salber, 1985). Since 2006 her life and her close relationship with her father have been documented through their voluminous correspondence, edited by Ingeborg Mayer-Palmedo and translated into English in 2014 (Freud & Freud, 2014). In his recent revisitation of her legacy, Thomas Aichorn (2016) aptly showed what a creative mixture of conservative and innovative (and reformistic) aspects her legacy stands for.

The Hampstead Child Therapy Clinic, founded by Anna Freud in 1947, became a worldwide leading institution for the training of child psychoanalysts and psychotherapists. In the mid-1950s a major research project was undertaken under the leadership of Joseph Sandler – the Hampstead Index Project (see Bolland and Sandler, 1985). Based on the reports written by the therapists about their clinical work, their findings were correlated under various headings by a team of researchers, the project aiming at a better integration between psychoanalytic theory and direct clinical observation. As a result, a large number of papers were published by Sandler and his coworkers, most of them in the *Psychoanalytic Study of the Child* and reprinted in Sandler (1987). A very good recent document of this creative climate and of Anna Freud's role in keeping it alive can be found in the volume edited by Daniel Benveniste *Anna Freud in the Hampstead Clinic: Letters to Humberto Nágera* (Benveniste, 2015), with particular regard to her specific interest in the conceptual, diagnostic, developmental, and structural aspects of analytic work.

A unique integration of all these aspects characterizes Anna Freud's 1965 book *Normality and pathology in childhood*, "one of the most important books of the Hartmann era" (Bergmann, 2000a, p. 49). Going beyond Karl Abraham's 1924 table of psychosexual phases (see Abraham, 1948) Anna Freud's concept of developmental lines allowed greater fluidity. In certain children, ego developments go further than their psychosexual development or their object relations. Each individual was now seen as a unique combination of various interacting lines of development. Around the ways in which such a developmental concept impacted on technique centered the 1980 volume *The technique of child psychoanalysis*, based on a series of seminars held by the authors (Joseph Sandler, Robert Tyson, and Hansi Kennedy) with Anna Freud (Sandler, Tyson, & Kennedy, 1980).

Pep in Europe after World War II

The Zurich analyst Gustav Bally played a very important role in Alexander Mitscherlich's life starting in the mid-1930 when, during the latter's exile, he became for him "some kind of a provisional psychotherapist" (see Hoyer, 2008, p. 89). Well documented by his biographer Timo Hoyer is Mitscherlich's 1951 six-month study trip to the USA and his "love relationship" with EP (p. 280). In fact, as a medical doctor working in Heidelberg, where he had graduated from medical school in 1941, he was one of the few German professionals whom the American army could trust, due to his opposition to the Nazi regime. An expert witness at

the Nuremberg Trials in 1946–1947, also thanks to North American donations, he was able to open in Heidelberg the first German university department of psychosomatic medicine and psychotherapy – a dream of his *Doktorvater* Viktor von Weizsäcker (1886–1957). Although he became a member of the German Psychoanalytic Association only in the early 1960s, after his training analysis with Paula Heimann (1899–1982) in London, the fact that he was the only German internationally well connected professor allowed him (together with the social scientists Horkheimer and Adorno) to invite the best representatives of international psychoanalysis to Frankfurt in 1956, to celebrate the 100th anniversary of Freud's birth.

In 1947, Mitscherlich had founded the journal *Psyche*, which greatly contributed to promoting the diffusion of Pep and North American EP, and which ended up playing in Germany a role similar to the one it played in the USA in terms of the delay in the reception of Kleinian psychoanalysis (see Bergmann, 2000a). Mitscherlich's intellectual brilliance and political skill allowed him to inaugurate in Frankfurt in 1960 the state-financed Sigmund Freud Institute, which played a very important role in the promotion of psychoanalysis in the years to come. This also allowed him to move from Heidelberg to Frankfurt as a university professor in 1967, and two years later to receive the Peace Prize of the German Publishers at Frankfurt's Paulskirche, with Heinz Kohut holding his *Laudatio* (see Kohut, 1971; Mitscherlich, 1972). Before his death in 1982, he published the autobiography *Ein Leben für die Psychoanalyse* (Mitscherlich, 1980). In other words, it makes sense to define Alexander Mitscherlich's relationship and contribution to Pep in terms of an "ego psychologist in action," aimed at healing German society of the psychological misery developed under the twelve years of the Nazi regime.

The definition of a specific diagnosis and therapy for the psychological problems connected with and caused by the Nazi regime was the topic of his most famous book, written by Mitscherlich with his wife Margarete Mitscherlich-Nielsen (1917–2012), *The inability to mourn. Principles of collective behavior* (1975; original German edition, 1967). In his review of the book for the *Psychoanalytic Quarterly*, George Pollock spoke of the authors as "important contributors to the psychoanalytic understanding of psychosocial issues and to the humanistic tradition of our science and profession" (Pollock, 1976, p. 306). Mitscherlich's theoretical work on this topic had already produced another book by him in 1963, which was also widely read in Germany, and translated into English in 1969 with the title *Society without the father: A contribution to social psychology*.

The book was promptly and very positively reviewed in the *Psychoanalytic Quarterly* by his good friend Henry Lowenfeld (1900–1985), a New York analyst who had worked with Fenichel in Prague after training in Berlin, that is:

His work is significant as one of the rare serious attempts to use the tools of psychoanalysis for an understanding of changing society and the impact of these changes on man's psychology. There is no doubt that the character of our patients has changed since Freud wrote his case histories, but our literature has thrown little light on this problem. And while Freud contributed so much to understanding of the civilization of his period, psychoanalysis has not contributed much to understanding of the present age, and of such problems as the growth of delinquency or the intellectual despair in cultural circles. The 'discontent in our civilization' has aspects other than those it had in the period when Freud wrote. Mitscherlich's effort is a step in the direction psychoanalysis must take to maintain its significant place in a changing civilization. (Lowenfeld, 1964, pp. 429–430)

Revisiting Alexander Mitscherlich's life and work, not only does Freud's "Civilization and its discontents" (1929) come to mind, but so too does his 1927 book "The future of an *illusion*," with particular regard to the famous phrase "The voice of the intellect is a soft one, but it does not rest till it has gained a hearing" (Freud, 1927, p. 53). This was, for example, the meaning of his several papers and books centered around a psychologically oriented urban planning, starting with Mitscherlich's 1965 book *Die Unwirtlichkeit unserer Städte* (Our inhospitable towns). As the German pioneer of an analytically oriented psychosomatic medicine, he worked in the direction of formulating a theory according to which any psychosomatic illness is preceded by a phase of purely psychological, that is, neurotic suffering, which we should pay attention to if we are to work also in terms of helping our patients prevent suffering on a physical level as well (see Mitscherlich, 1966, 1967).

Given his ego-psychologically oriented social orientation and commitment, Mitscherlich had the chance to coordinate a panel on "Protest and revolution" (Mitscherlich & Francis, 1970) at the IPA Congress held in Rome in 1969, and to give a paper on "Psychoanalysis and the aggression of large groups" (Mitscherlich, 1971) at the 1971 IPA Congress held in Vienna. Invited to present a paper at the New York Psychoanalytic Institute, on April 13, 1976, Mitscherlich spoke about "Group psychology and the analysis of the ego – A lifetime later" (Mitscherlich, 1978), insisting on the fact that the critical faculty of the individual ego represents the only safeguard against the pull of mass regression.

Last but not least, Alexander Mitscherlich played a major role not only in reconnecting the German with the international analytic community, but also in inspiring – indirectly and directly – several generations of leading German analysts (see also Bohleber, 2004). To the first group belongs Horst-Eberhard Richter (1923–2011), and also Johannes Cremerius. To the second group belong not only Hermann Argelander and Helmut Thomä (1921–2013), but also Wolfgang Loch (1915–1995) – all three of them direct collaborators of his. Their common denominator is the fact that, except for Thomä (with particular regard to his work with Horst Kächele [1944–2021]), none of them is well enough known in the English-speaking analytic world.

If we take the case of Johannes Cremerius, we can say that he played a very important role in both Germany and Italy in promoting an ego-psychologically oriented analytic work, both through his work as a training analyst and supervisor, and through his many technical papers. Collected in the 1990 anthology *Vom Handwerk des Psychoanalytikers: Das Werkzeug der psychoanalytischen Technik* (The work of the psychoanalyst: The instruments of analytic technique; Cremerius, 1990), they deal with the defense mechanisms active in a whole series of patients – that is, those who talk too much, those who talk too little, and patients with superego problems – and with how to deal with them. Later in his life, Cremerius became a pioneer of the German reception of the work of Balint and Ferenczi, but he never gave up the ego-psychological basis of his way of working (see Conci, 2019, Chapter 10). In his 1994 autobiographical portrait, he, for example, wrote extensively of his meeting with Rudolph Loewenstein in New York in 1950, and his regular contacts with both Kurt Eissler and Otto Kernberg (Cremerius, 1994).

To Hermann Argelander we owe the very important concept of what our German colleagues call *szenisches Verstehen*, which can be retraced back to what we can call a *szenische Funktion des Ichs*, that is, a "scenic function of the ego" (see Argelander, 1970; Conci, 2017). In fact, in a whole series of papers Argelander presented our analytic work in terms of a dialogue which carries with it, involves, and/or requires the analyst's participation in the emotional life of the patient. The relationship resulting from such an interaction will allow the patient to express the unconscious conflicts which brought them to ask the analyst for help in terms of concrete unconscious behaviors and/or more or less structured scenes, to whose realization the analyst themselves will more or less consciously give their own contribution. As we can see, implicit in Argelander's concept are both Sullivan's concept of "participant

observation” and Sandler’s concept of “role responsiveness” – and we can thus look at all three sets of concepts, Argelander’s, Sullivan’s and Sandler’s, as very important functions of the ego and/or as crucial concepts of Pep. But here is how Werner Bohleber introduced readers of the *International Journal of Psychoanalysis* to the English translation of Argelander’s paper “Die szenische Funktion des Ichs und ihr Anteil an der Symptom- und Charakterbildung” (see Argelander, 2013; originally published 1970), which he was able to promote in 2013:

The scene is a dynamic construction shared by analyst and patient, a creation of both parties and not something from the past that is simply found. Scenic understanding is ultimately a modern constructivist concept that was ahead of its time. However, Argelander’s thinking always preserved its links to ego psychology. An approach analogous in some respects to his can be discerned in Madeleine and Willy Baranger’s view of the analytic situation as a ‘dynamic field’ – these authors too had taken up some of the ideas of Gestalt psychology – as well as in modern intersubjectivist conceptions of the analytic situation as always being a co-creation of the analyst and the patient. (Bohleber, 2013, p. 335)

Also worth mentioning is the fact that the following two paradoxes accompany Argelander’s concept. On the one hand, the concept is not as much known abroad as it should be. On the other hand, it is very widely used in Germany. Not only does every German analytic candidate have to become familiar with the “scene” which the patient and analyst produce during the first session(s), but its description is usually also an essential part of the reports that all German analysts must write for the German Social Security System, in order to have their work financially covered – up to 300 sessions with a three times a week frequency. But as only a minority of the German colleagues who use such a concept daily seem to be still aware of its ego-psychological origin, it is as if, like Moliere’s *bourgeois gentilhomme*, they spoke “prose” without knowing it. Michael Wolf, dealing with it in the abovementioned *Handbuch der psychoanalytischen Grundbegriffe* (Wolf, 2008), privileges discussing the hermeneutic point of view which Argelander shared with Alfred Lorenzer as the intellectual background of “the scenic function of the ego” – as the latter formulated it in his 1970 book *Sprachzerstörung und Rekonstruktion* (Destruction and reconstruction of language). Given the interest in this topic – and in the overall topic of the relationship between the German and the international analytic community – I dealt with it in the Interview which (together with Ingrid Erhardt) I conducted with Horst Kächele in 2013 (see Conci, 2019, Chapter 12).

As far as the limited international circulation of the concept of “scenic understanding” is concerned, an important role is certainly played by the sense of ambivalence that our German colleagues experience concerning their system of financial coverage – the context in which the concept of “scenic understanding” plays such an important role – which takes place not directly through the patients, but through a “third party.” Instead of being proud of such a system, as was the case for Helmut Thomä and Horst Kächele (see Thomä and Kächele, 1985, 1988), who based on it not only their empirical research, but also their technical perspective, many colleagues fear that, by working as they do in Germany, they will end up falling outside of the basic parameters promoted by the IPA. I am referring to a concept of analytic work as defined through the high frequency of sessions (more than three sessions a week), and through its “open-ended” character, as opposed to the 300 sessions covered by the German Social Security System. At the same time, such a fear is justified by the resistances of several sectors of the IPA against disconnecting their concept of psychoanalysis from a specific number of sessions, and accepting the variety of ways in which psychoanalysis can be practiced (see Conci, 2019) – not only with adults, but also with children; not only with individuals, but also with groups; not only with neurotic patients, but also with psychotic ones. This is, in my view – as an Italian psychoanalyst working in Germany – why our German colleagues do not find it as easy to internationally promote the concept of “scenic understanding” as it deserves.

Indeed, by carefully reading Volume 1 of their handbook *Psychoanalytic practice* – a volume entitled *Principles* – we can become aware not only of how much the original new perspective developed by Helmut Thomä and Horst Kächele was influenced by Michael Balint’s (1896–1970) “focal analytic concept,” but also of how much it is embedded in the whole body of Pep, to which they refer in a much less explicit way. When we speak of psychoanalysis in terms of “analytic therapy” (this the title of their handbook), and we present it as a form of treatment that we can study empirically and divided into a series of phases, in which patients defend themselves in a specific way according to their personality structure, and we can develop a “therapeutic alliance” with them, etc., we certainly work in line with the principles of Pep – which the authors seem to take for granted and do not make sufficiently explicit. None of these principles belongs, for example, to the Bionian way of working which has lately become such an important model in the international analytic community.

In the light of Paul Parin's work inside and outside our institutions, the Zurich colleague Thomas Kurz (2017) classified him as belonging – together with Alexander Mitscherlich and Johannes Cremerius – to the so-called “Freudian Left” (see Jacoby, 1983), founded by Otto Fenichel. For all of them, Pep was the best perspective from which to study the relationship between the individual and their society, and this to the point that Parin based on it the ethno-psychoanalytic research work he conducted in the 1950s–1960s in West Africa with his wife Goldy Parin-Matth  y and Fritz Morgenthaler (1919–1984). Born in 1916 in Graz (Austria), Parin grew up in Slovenia and studied medicine in Graz, Zagabria, and Zurich, where he graduated in 1943. Together with his future wife Goldy, he worked for the Red Cross in Yugoslavia during the two last years of the war, and then went back to Zurich, where he trained as a neurologist and underwent his training analysis with Rudolf Brun (1885–1969).

After opening his private practice with his wife and Fritz Morgenthaler in 1952, between 1955 and 1971 they made six field trips to West Africa, through which they gave a crucial contribution to the new field of ethno-psychoanalysis. In 1963 they published *Die Weissen denken zuviel. Psychoanalytische Untersuchungen bei den Dogon in Westafrika* (White people think too much. Psychoanalytic field work with the Dogon in West Africa; Parin, Parin-Matth  y, & Morgenthaler, 1963), and in 1971 *F  rchte deinen N  chsten wie dich selbst. Psychoanalyse und Gesellschaft am Modell der Agni in Westafrika* (Fear your neighbor like yourself. Psychoanalysis and society in the work with the Agni of West Africa; Parin, Parin-Matth  y, & Morgenthaler, 1970), the two books that made them internationally famous.

In 1958, together with Jacques Berna, the three colleagues founded the “Psychoanalytische Seminar Z  rich,” which made itself autonomous from the Swiss Society in 1977 (see Kurz, 1993). Paul Parin was an active participant in the IPA congresses from 1959 (see, for example, Morgenthaler and Parin, 1964), and was the president of the Swiss Society between 1967 and 1974 (see also Haynal, 2017). In June 1973 he gave a paper at the symposium organized by Ernest Wolf for Heinz Kouht's 60th birthday (Parin, Levine, & Friedman, 1975; Strozier, 2001). He is also internationally known for a series of politically committed papers (see Parin 1975, 1978, 1985) based on his ego-psychological and ethnological perspective and work.

Here is how Paul Parin spoke of his ethno-psychoanalytic work in Chicago in 1973, not only in terms of the revisitation of Freud's structural model, but also in terms of how such a work can throw new light on the nature of psychoanalysis as a social science:

Our studies of the Dogon and the Agni point to some typical features of the superego and the ego that shed light on the question of whether psychoanalysis is a social science. Differentiated from the ego, a superego was found in each culture to be the successor to earlier object relations and the carrier of idealized representations. However, it seems to originate out of very diversified phases and developmental steps, and in its functions it appears to be far more dependent on the actual environment than heretofore believed. This form of superego we call ‘clan conscience’. In characterizing the ego of normal persons in these cultures, we speak of ‘group ego’. This is our term for a special molding of the ego. The adult ego is largely dependent on the typical psychological makeup of the individuals in the environment and on specific behavior patterns in the social setting that warrant ego autonomy, as Rapaport conceived of this term. What seems to be a close dependence of the individual on figures and institutions within the social network enriches the ego with mechanisms contributing to its proper functioning. These results of the ethno-analytic confrontation suggest that we should review some psychoanalytical concepts established in our culture in the light of social factors. Above all, we should study the extent to which the impact of macrosocial environment sets limits to the autonomy and to the functioning of even a mature psychic structure, a well-established superego, and an ego oriented to the reality principle. (Parin et al., 1975, pp. 378–379)

This is exactly the line of theoretical and clinical research that we find articulated in Paul Parin's 1977 paper “Das Ich und die Anpassungs-Mechanismen” (The ego and the mechanisms of adaptation), a title explicitly meant by him as a reminder of Anna Freud's (1936; English 1946) and Heinz Hartmann's (1939; English 1958) seminal contributions. In fact, here is the summary accompanying its publication in the journal *Psyche*:

The ‘ethno-psychoanalytic’ study of personalities belonging to different cultural areas and the attentive analysis of socially relevant attitudes in the classical psychoanalytical setting in Europe gave way to a renewed approach to Ego Psychology. Under the impact of social influences, mechanisms of adaptation are established which function automatically and unconsciously and provide a relative stability to the Ego structure. The description of three different mechanisms — called Group-Ego, Clan-Conscience and Identification with the (social) Role — is mainly based on genetic and dynamic considerations. The vicissitudes, the functions and the deteriorations of these mechanisms are discussed. The spread of narcissistic disorders in today's industrial society may be derived from an increment of identifications with the role and a resulting overemphasis of narcissistic needs. (Parin, 1977, p. 514)

A good way of characterizing Joseph Sandler's work and legacy is to quote the words with which Otto Kernberg opened and closed his contribution to the monographic issue of the North American journal *Psychoanalytic Inquiry* dedicated to him and edited by Melvin Bornstein in 2005:

I believe it is fair to say that Joseph Sandler has contributed more than anybody else to the integration of classical ego psychology with contemporary object relations theory, at both the theoretical and the clinical level. (Kernberg, 2005, p. 174)

His closing words were:

Finally, the concern over the lack of research and innovation in psychoanalytic education is a major unfinished task that Joseph Sandler has left for us, together with the other, major task that overshadows the rest, namely, that of strengthening psychoanalytic research so as to ensure the future of our science as well as of our profession. (Kernberg, 2005, p. 182)

A concise revisitation of Sandler's life and work can be found in the 2001 obituary published by Peter Fonagy in the *International Journal of Psychoanalysis*.

To Peter Fonagy and Mary Target we also owe the best overview of Joseph Sandler's main concepts, as they summarized them in Chapter 4 of their 2003 handbook *Psychoanalytic theories. Perspectives from developmental psychopathology*, after having dealt with the developmental models of Anna Freud and Margaret Mahler (1897–1985). The main publications of Sandler to which Fonagy and Target introduce the reader in their book are “The background of safety” (1960a; also in Sandler, 1987), “The concept of superego” (1960b; also in Sandler, 1987), “The Hampstead Index as a method of psychoanalytic research” (1962; also in Sandler, 1987), “The representational world” (with Bernard Rosenblatt, 1962; also in Sandler, 1987), “Toward a basic psychoanalytic model” (with Walter Joffe, 1969; also in Sandler, 1987), “The role of affects in psychoanalytic theory” (1972; also in Sandler, 1987), “Countertransference and role-responsiveness” (1976), “On the development of object relationships and affects” (with Anne-Marie Sandler; Sandler & Sandler, 1978), “The ‘second censorship’, the ‘three-box model’ and some technical implications” (with Anne-Marie Sandler; Sandler & Sandler, 1983), “Reflections on some relations between psychoanalytic concepts and psychoanalytic practice” (1983), “The past unconscious, the present unconscious, and interpretation of the transference” (with Anne-Marie Sandler; Sandler & Sandler 1984), and “On the structure of internal objects and internal objects relationships” (1990). Half of these papers were reprinted in the 1987 anthology *From safety to*

superego, and are therefore not reported in the References to this article, unlike his other papers and the following books: *The patient and the analyst* (with Christopher Dare and Axel Holder; Sandler, Dare, & Holder, 1973), *The technique of child psychoanalysis* (with Robert Tyson and Hansi Kennedy; Sandler et al., 1980), *The analysis of defense* (with Anna Freud; Sandler & Freud, 1985), *What do psychoanalysts want? The problem of aims in psychoanalytic therapy* (with Anna Ursula Dreher; Sandler & Dreher, 1996), and *Internal object revisited* (with Anne-Marie Sandler; Sandler & Sandler, 1998). In 1999, Peter Fonagy edited together with Arnold Cooper and Robert Wallerstein an anthology of papers in Sandler's honor with the title *Psychoanalysis on the move – The work of Joseph Sandler* (Fonagy, Cooper, & Wallerstein, 1999), and in 2005 he also contributed to the above mentioned monographic issue with “An overview of Joseph Sandler's key contributions to theoretical and clinical psychoanalysis” (Fonagy, 2005).

Although the work of Joseph Sandler has been well received and widely assimilated throughout Europe, as for example in Italy and in Germany, it is possible that many colleagues work ego-psychologically without actually knowing it. As far as Italy is concerned, this is where the anthology *From safety to superego* was originally conceived, as Joseph Sandler himself wrote in the Acknowledgments of the book. As far as Germany is concerned, Anne-Marie Sandler played a crucial role in the readmission of the German Psychoanalytic Society to the IPA (in Chicago, 2009), as she herself wrote in detail in her “Selbstdarstellung” (Autobiography; see A.-M. Sandler, 2015). It is true that Fonagy and Target (2003) themselves, in their final “Critique and evaluation,” state that the Sandler's particular sophistication and humility did not allow them to transform their approach into a product which our colleagues could associate with their names. Their priority was the revision and extension of Freud's work, as opposed to the creation of their own school or brand of psychoanalysis.

In his 1978 Preface to Hartmann's *Psicologia dell'Io e problema dell'adattamento*, the Italian pioneer of psychoanalysis Franco Fornari (1921–1985) was rather critical of the former's concept of ego autonomy, and revisited his EP in terms of its having been an exaggerated reaction to the definition of human beings in terms of their being driven by sexuality and aggression (Fornari, 1978). Hartmann's EP never occupied a central role in the work of reception of a whole series of analytic perspectives which characterized Italian psychoanalysis in the 1950s–1980s (see Conci, 2019). From this point of view,

an exception is represented by the work of Stefano Bolognini (see, for example, 2011), in which are to be found a whole series of themes coming from North American ego and self psychology – with particular regard to the work of Roy Schafer (see Conci, 2019, Chapter 11). As far as the literature of Pep and EP is concerned, its publication in Italian was mainly due to Pier Francesco Galli, a collaborator of Gaetano Benedetti (see Galli, 2013; Migone, 2019) – including the initiative of publishing in Italian Heinz Hartmann’s 1927 *Grundlagen der Psychoanalyse*, not yet translated into English.

Final considerations

In the Introduction, Pep was defined as a necessary phase in the development of psychoanalysis and as an analytic perspective variously developed according to the personality, and to the clinical and theoretical priorities, of the psychoanalysts who dealt with and formulated it, before and after World War II in Europe. On such a basis, I formulated the hypothesis that it makes sense to distinguish it from Heinz Hartmann’s branch of psychoanalytic ego psychology, that is, the so-called EP – at variance with the lack of such a distinction present in the Italian, German, and French literature mentioned above.

From this point of view, my line of thought developed in a parallel direction to the one pursued by Ulrike May, as, for example, it came to fruition in her 2004 article on the original formulation of the concepts of “self-” and “object-representation” by Otto Fenichel and Edith Jacobson (1897–1978) before World War II. But here is the way in which she formulated it in her 2020 “Selbstdarstellung”, in connection with her meeting Margaret Mahler vacationing in Bavaria in the summer of 1977. In fact, she did it in a way which echoes the (not only scientific, but also political) deficits of international communication and dialogue in our field described by André Green and Otto Kernberg in the quotation reported at the beginning of this article. Here are Ulrike May’s words:

While talking with Mahler, Edith Jacobson called her up – a very exciting event for me. Jacobson had been Mahler’s analyst, and they later became friends, and – as I understood only many years later, in 2004 – it was she who had introduced the concept of ‘self-representation’ at the beginning of the 1950s, which later Hartmann took up from her. Or, at least, this is what Jacobson stated in an interview. If what I imagine is true, we can say that Hartmann must have had an important debt vis-à-vis both, Jacobson and Mahler. Perhaps I might still have the chance to revisit and deepen this whole story, which might change our image of *ego psychology*. In the meantime,

some sectors of the IPA look at it – mistakenly, according to me – as a wrong direction. This probably depends on the fact that *ego psychology* is reduced to its formulation by Hartmann, while other authors like Mahler, Greenacre, and Annie Reich, or Jacobson herself, have been forgotten. (May, 2020, p. 122; emphasis in the original)

As the readers of this article can see, it was not only possible to articulate such a relationship in the light of its different protagonists and their specific interests, but also to redefine Pep in terms of a still important although often neglected branch of psychoanalysis. From this point of view, it is true that all of us psychoanalysts orient our work – as Otto Fenichel used to say – on the ego of our patients, but we apparently do it so automatically that we fail to integrate such a work into our self-image and into our theory. This is particularly true not only for the German concept of “*szenisches Verstehen*,” but also for the fascinating and very useful work of reformulation of “analytic therapy” made by Helmut Thomä and Horst Kächele.

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